Twelve Everyday Things to Notice About What Your Wife Enjoys, Chooses and Looks Forward To

What to notice about her ordinary days and how to write it down as a question for her, with nothing to read into it.

After all these years you know your wife's days by heart. You may never have written down which parts of them she'd call the good ones. This guide names twelve everyday things worth noticing and, for each, what to write down.

This isn't a watch for anything. She is well, and nothing on this list is a sign of something else. Each note is a question to bring to her, because noticing can't stand in for asking: the National Institute on Aging says the best way to know what someone needs is to ask them directly. There's nothing secret about it, either. Tell her what you're doing, and show her the page if she's curious.

The idea of looking at good days, routines and rituals follows a federal toolkit on person-centered thinking and the Conversation Project's starter guide. The twelve items and the wording about what to write down are ours.

Her mornings and evenings

1 How she starts the day [1]

NOTICE The order of her morning: the coffee, the paper, the radio, the walk, and which comes first.

WRITE DOWN The routine as you see it, and a question for her: which part would she least want to give up?

2 How she ends the day [1]

NOTICE What the last hour looks like: a program, a book, a phone call, a turn around the house before bed.

WRITE DOWN What you see. Whether it's a habit or something that matters to her is hers to say, so ask.

3 The days she'd call good ones [2] [3]

NOTICE The days she says went well, and what was in them.

WRITE DOWN Her words about the day, as close to how she said them as you can get.

Her week and her year

4 Standing dates [1]

NOTICE The things that come around every week or month: bridge on Thursdays, church, the book club, lunch with a friend.

WRITE DOWN What, when and with whom.

5 The dates she keeps [1]

NOTICE Birthdays, anniversaries, holidays, the visits she plans around.

WRITE DOWN Which ones she organizes herself. What she likes about doing it is a question for her.

6 What she looks forward to [3]

NOTICE What she mentions ahead of time, puts on the calendar, or gets ready for early.

WRITE DOWN The thing, and what she says about it.

Her home and her own way of doing things

7 The jobs she keeps for herself

NOTICE The things she does her own way and doesn't hand off: the cooking, the garden, the holiday table, the Christmas cards.

WRITE DOWN Which ones, and a question for her: is it the doing she enjoys, or having it done her way?

8 Her places

NOTICE Where she likes to be: a chair, the porch, the kitchen, a particular pew or table.

WRITE DOWN The places, and what she does there.

9 The choices she makes every day [4]

NOTICE What she decides without a second thought: when she gets up, what she eats, what she wears, when she goes out.

WRITE DOWN The choices that are plainly hers. Then ask her directly which ones she'd most want to keep making herself.

Her people

10 Who she calls and sees

NOTICE Who she phones, who drops by, who she goes out of her way for.

WRITE DOWN Names, and how often. No ranking.

11 Who she turns to [2] [3]

NOTICE Who she talks to when something is on her mind.

WRITE DOWN What you've seen, and a question for her: who would she want in a conversation about the years ahead?

Her own words

12 What she says in passing [3]

NOTICE The remarks that come out on their own: “I'd never give up this kitchen,” “I do love a quiet morning.”

WRITE DOWN The sentence, word for word, with the date. Don't interpret it. Bring it up once she has agreed to talk.

If something about her health is on your mind

This list isn't for that. It's about what she enjoys and chooses, and nothing on it calls for a phone call. If you do have a concern about her health, the National Institute on Aging's suggestion is a visit to a health care provider. That is a conversation for her and her doctor, not something to work out from these notes.

What this guide doesn't do

It doesn't say what any of this means, and it isn't a way of keeping an eye on her. Nothing here measures how she is doing. It helps you bring better questions to a conversation she has agreed to have, and her answers are the ones that count.

Ready for the next step?

You've noticed what makes her days hers and written it down as questions for her. When you're both ready, the care interview walks you through the rest of her situation area by area and turns your answers into a Family Care Profile you can bring to any care conversation.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›

WHERE THIS COMES FROM

1. Administration for Community Living (National Center on Advancing Person-Centered Practices and Systems), Office of Healthcare Information and Counseling Person-Centered Thinking Toolkit
2. The Conversation Project (Institute for Healthcare Improvement), Your Conversation Starter Guide: How to talk about what matters to you and have a say in your health care
3. Institute for Healthcare Improvement (Age-Friendly Health Systems, with The John A. Hartford Foundation), “What Matters” to Older Adults? A Toolkit for Health Systems to Design Better Care with Older Adults
4. National Institute on Aging, Does an Older Adult in Your Life Need Help?